

CHAPTER 21

THE PAK COMMANDO JOKE

'They got intelligence inputs.'

So, here was the most ridiculous of rumours, which only the Kerala police may lap up: a Pakistani commando force was going to storm the Viyyur Jail or airdrop troops to rescue the accused in the ISRO spy case. Evidently someone who wanted to buttress the Pakistan angle of the ISRO spy case had a fertile imagination. And there was this ready regiment of blockheads eager to buy the story.

We were not aware of the rumour, but were surprised to see a sudden flurry of unusual activities in the prison. Our cells were given an extra check and we were patted down. Battalions of policemen were brought in to guard our cells, and an extra ring of security was thrown around the block. Senior officers paced the corridors up and down. The jail superintendent's phone kept ringing. Guards suspiciously looked at us from a safe distance, occasionally whispering at each other. This vigil continued through the night, and the next morning.

When things were back to normal that afternoon, I asked Sivanandan what it was all about.

'Shh…' the assistant jailor gestured me to speak in a low voice. 'They got intelligence inputs that Pakistanis will be storming the jail to rescue you guys.'

I roared with laughter. Sivanandan ran away.